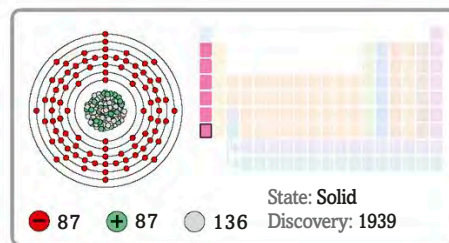


87

Fr

Francium



Thorite

This mineral was discovered in 1828 in Norway.



MARGUERITE PEREY



The French chemist Marguerite Perey discovered francium in 1939 while studying the way a pure sample of another radioactive metal – actinium – decayed. She found that actinium broke down to form thorium and a previously unknown element. She named this element francium after her home country.

The dark crust is a uranium mineral that holds tiny amounts of francium.

Earth's rocks have **one** francium **atom** for every million trillion uranium atoms.

Uraninite

Francium is the rarest natural element on Earth. Scientists think there may be just 30 g (1.1 oz) of francium in Earth's rocks. Francium atoms are created when radioactive elements break down. Francium can be extracted from radioactive ores such as

thorite and **uraninite**, both of which contain tiny amounts of this element. Even so, to date the largest sample of the metal made contained only 300,000 atoms, and lasted only a few days. Francium has no known uses outside of research.